

Kaweah Jamboree + SAR

When: August 20th to 27th, 2011

People who wish they got to ride out in a helicopter: Jen Blackie, Amin Faraday, James Barlow, Keith Christensen

Full Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157627549153396/>

GPS Track: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/6094602282/sizes/o/in/set-72157627549153396/>

(*Note* For those interested just in the helicopter rescue and ensuing saga please skip to the end of day 6 where the sudden gravitational opposition event starts)

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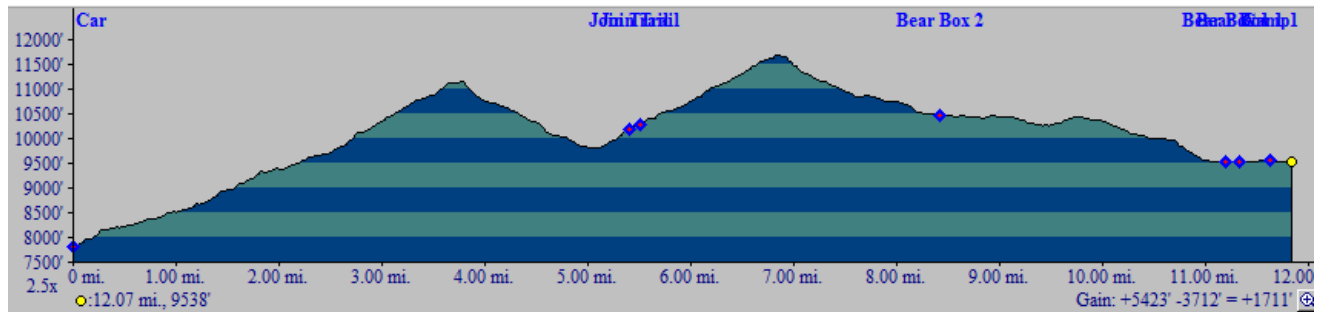
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Back when I first started becoming aware of the Sierra Peaks two mountains stood out as being reputedly difficult and scary. The first was Devils Crag which Jen and I recently did and found to be exposed but solid and all around a spectacular climb. The second was Black Kaweah, famous for being so loose that it was like “climbing a library” according to at least one climber who told me how he had turned back short of the summit twice.

Black Kaweah also has the distinction of being rather far in requiring a longer trip to bag. So while Jen and I banged out Devils Crag over a long haul three day weekend the plan that eventually came about for Kaweah involved a 9 day mega peak bag.

Oh and I'd decided to name the WTC group I was launching Kaweah which made me want to get out there all the more.

Day One: Hard Haul From Mineral King To Big Arroyo



It was a rather long road from wanting to do this trip to finally getting some people to commit to go with me.

In the end I ended up with Jen Blackie, Amin Faraday, and James Barlow for the entire trip with Keith Christenson tagging along for the first 4 days to grab Mt and Black Kaweah.

Our plan was to clean out the peaks in the Kaweah area including the named non-SPS list bumps and finish with somewhere north of 9 peaks. Granted being out there for 9 days there was a greater than slight chance weather or other factors would impact us at some point but it did give us some flexibility.

Due to my usual flight back to Orange County running late Jen and I weren't able to leave until after 9 pm which had us arriving at a full Atwell Campground a bit before 2. Fortunately we stumbled across James Barlow's car and were able to sleep in his site for a few hours.

We were there for the 8 am opening of the rangers' office to pick up our permit. Surprisingly there was only one other party there. This was a striking difference from a few weeks back when there'd been a line out the door. Apparently smoke from the fire on the other side of Farwell Gap was impacting air quality and had scared most folks off.

We were headed far enough in that it hopefully wouldn't bother us.



Permit in hand we went to the Sawtooth trailhead and packed up. In addition to my usual load I was carrying a rope bag filled with extra food. Granted most of it was dehydrated meals but the overall load was probably the heaviest I'd carried this season.

The hike in was going to be over 10 miles and 5k+ gain







Glacier Pass was the first big obstacle but we had clear weather and a decent trail .



Looking over the top we could see Black Rock Pass in the foreground on the other side of a depressingly large canyon followed by the Kaweahs off in the distance.



There was still a bit of snow on the far side.



We passed a beautiful little spot at Spring Lake while traversing the canyon and talked about possibly spending the last night there.

The climb up Black Rock was a bit of a slog but after a quick shortcut we had a good trail to pound up.



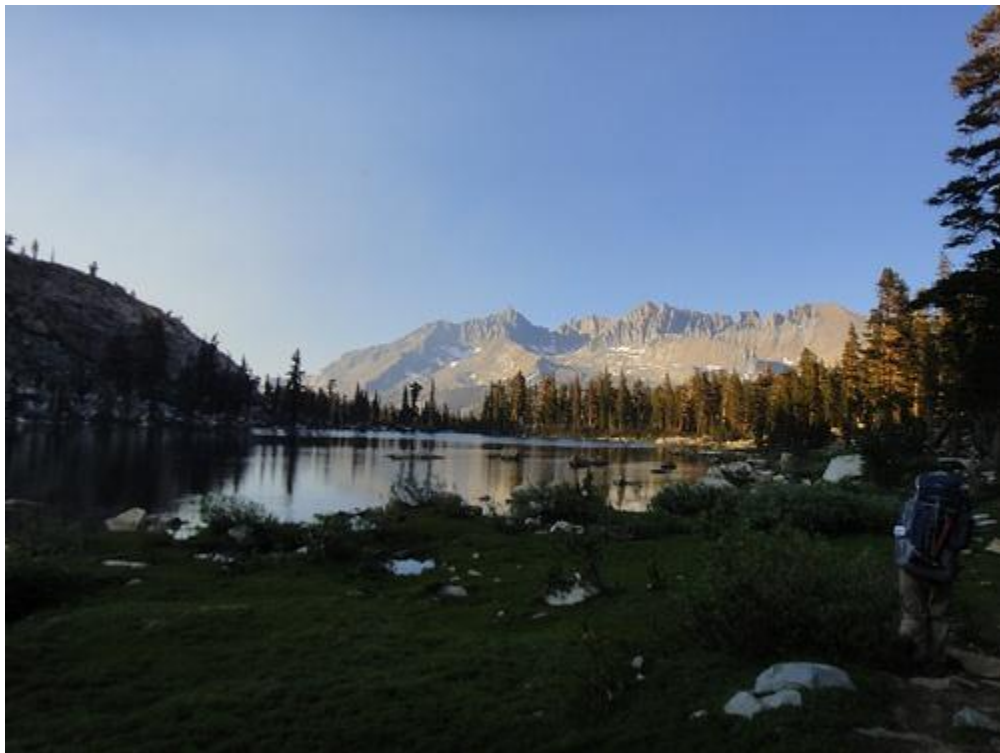
Finally we could see the area we'd be spending the next week in. We'd be descending through Five Lakes Basin to Big Arroyo where we'd stash a big chunk of our food in the backcountry bear box and spend the first night. We'd then set out for a three day excursion to the shelf below Red, Black, and Mt Kaweah.



While climbing Black Rock Pass a deer had wandered up and tailed us to the top where he proceeded to inspect us at length. He was noticeably skinny and had his mouth hanging open in an odd manner. We all decided he was acting oddly and decided to hurry down before we ended up with mad deer disease.



From here it was all downhill until we could finally get rid of all this extra weight.



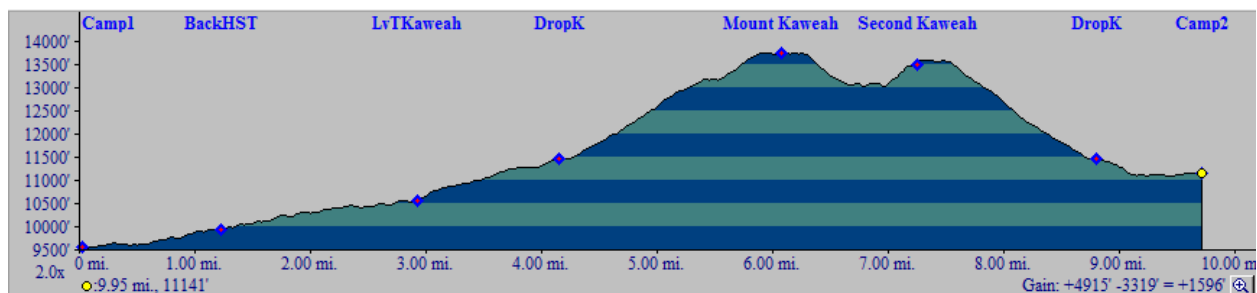
The lakes along the way were pretty but the mosquitoes were atrocious. I did my best to avoid any stops despite everyone being tired as I was getting eaten alive the moment I wasn't moving. Everyone was dragging a bit at this point.



At long last we pulled into Big Arroyo right around dark. After asking some rather dickish campers where the box was (they told us it was full because there were 15 of them) we found the box and with a little encouragement dumped in everything except for 4 days worth of food (basically what could fit in our bear cans.)

All the sites close to the box were taken but as the crowd was rather loud we found a decent camp a ways off in the trees. Everyone set up, ate, and went to bed quickly.

Day Two: Repositioning Camp, Mt Kaweah, and Second Kaweah



When the sun came up we could finally get a look at where exactly we'd made camp. It was clear others had camped here before but it was close enough to a rather stagnant water source we all wanted to be gone before it warmed up enough for the mosquitoes to emerge for the day. Fortunately for the moment it was cold enough we had some relief.



This is the patrol cabin at Big Arroyo. Both times we came through it was buttoned up tight.



We had an uphill climb along the HST which was a nice chance to stretch my legs under a noticeably lighter load.



Once up on the shelf below the Kaweahs we dropped our camping gear and bear cans and started the slog up to Mt Kaweah.

We'd heard the registers up here had been trashed and sure enough we found an obviously newly placed paint can with a few scraps of paper. I dropped an SPS book and we pushed on to the next goal after taking the requisite pictures.









The next bump over is labeled Second Kaweah on the map. James, Jen, and myself decided we all wanted to tag it and strolled over while the other two descended back to the gear we'd dropped.



From here there's a series of crags down a ridge that looked somewhere between precarious and unclimbable. I was tempted to go for the nearest one but we still had a ways to go before camp and a full day ahead of us tomorrow.



Jen and I decided to come back for them another trip and headed down.

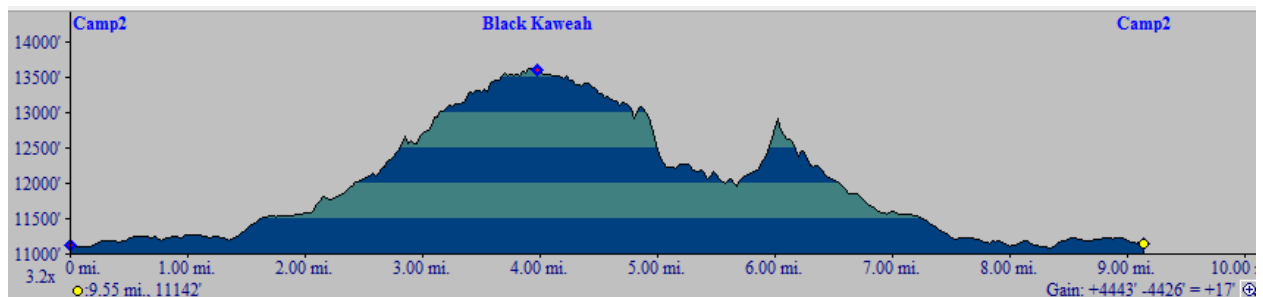
The shelf actually had quite a few nice campsites with plenty of water available. Unfortunately we weren't high enough to get away from the mosquitoes though.



We found a camp below Red Kaweah and settled in for the night. With the mosquito hordes outside I took my meal inside the tent rather than be social.



Day Three: Black Kaweah



With Keith only with us through Tuesday we prioritized the other high value peak, Black Kaweah. While Mt Kaweah was the SPS emblem this one was a SPS mountaineer's peak and the dominant peak in the area.

As I mentioned before it had a reputation for being so loose that it was like "climbing a library"

We had a nice view of it right from camp.



The route involved traversing along the shelf we were camping on to a southern drainage and climbing the southwest face.

I wasn't feeling well that morning but wasn't about to miss the climb.



The approach was the usual mix of snow and loose rock.



This is the start of the actual route up the peak.









The route had some third class and a lot of second class. The rock we were climbing wasn't loose so much as every ledge and flat bit had a large amount of loose rock sitting on it.



We took it slow and called out any pieces we kicked off.



We made steady progress and soon popped out near the top.





There used to be a very old register up at the top of Black Kaweah. Instead we found ripped pieces of paper and this sheet decrying the destruction.

AUGUST 18, 2011
DOUG CUMMINGS
KIRK TAYLOR (THE POODLE)
SUMMITED THE (THE MATH TEACHER)
BLACK KAWEAH
UNDER A PERFECT SKY
AND FELT THE BITTER STING
OF A CRIME AGAINST HUMANITY
TO WIT: THE PRICELESS
ORIGINAL REGISTER APPEARS TO
HAVE BEEN STOLEN. WE HOPE IT'S
BEING TAKEN CARE OF, BUT
WE FEAR THE WORST. THIS
PAGE, A SEASHELL + PART OF A
PENCIL IS ALL WE FOUND.
FARWELL, ME HEARTIES.
KIT. WTF?? The Poodle
Will find you... Dee

No sign of the old register canister even except for these bits.



We did the best we could to rig a temporary container and made a note to let the group headed up here in a few weeks know to bring something more permanent.



And now to get down. The weather was looking somewhat questionable and we didn't particularly want to be on the rocks during a rainstorm.

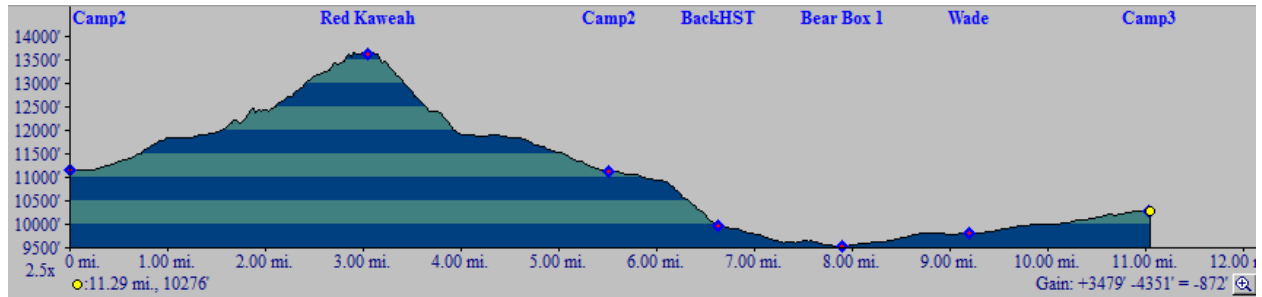


We backtracked down the same route and it was largely uneventful.



The weather held and we made it back to camp with daylight to spare. Keith had to get to work in a few days and so left at this point to head for Big Arroyo and hike out the following day. The rest of us ate a well deserved meal and turned in early again.

Day Four: Red Kaweah And Reposition



Red Kaweah was located between Mt Kaweah and Black Kaweah. It was named for the striking red color of the rock but the climb isn't anything special.



Black is to the left, red to the right.



We had some great views of Black on the way up the drainage.



Then the climb itself. Lots of large and only somewhat loose boulders that were more annoying than anything else.



This one actually had a canister up top. I was tempted to relocate it to Black but we had other plans.



I attempted to do a kung fu summit picture...



(Someone didn't follow the photographer's directions...)



The descent was straightforward.



As we exited the drainage back on to the shelf we could hear voices. Eventually we identified some climbers trying a direct route up the face of Red. They were just getting off the snow and seemed to be struggling a bit and spreading out across different chutes.



We dropped back to camp and packed everything up. Instead of returning to the HST along the shelf we decided to try and drop down the slope below directly.



It worked though a few of the looser sections were a bit of a pain with full packs. But soon enough we popped back on to the HST and moseyed back to Big Arroyo.



Here we hit a bit of a snag. We'd left the majority of our food in the bear box intending to refill our cans and head off for another few days. Jen's was missing.

She kept insisting one of us was playing a joke on her but sure enough it was gone. It had been in a black stuff sack with her name on it so I can only assume it was someone who made a mistake and didn't realize it until they were already down the trail but that's still a crummy mistake to make.

We had enough spare food between us to share with Jen so we restocked, returned the remainder of the food back to the box, and continued up the trail towards 9 Lake Basin.



A mile or two up there was a rather pleasant stream crossing that gave us the chance to strip off our boots and soak our feet.



And other bits.

Looking down from the Kaweah's I knew the basin itself was rather desolate so my general plan was to climb until we ran out of trees. Not far past the crossing most of the trees were already rather stunted and lacking.



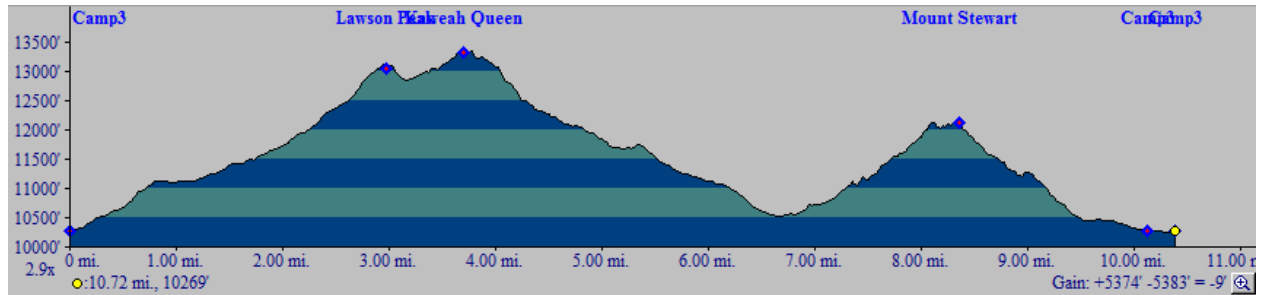
I wanted to get away from the HST and that proved to be a challenge.



Eventually I took us back across the streams to a clump of trees where we found some rather nice spots to pitch out tents and settle down for the next few days.



Day Five: Lawson, Queen Kaweah, and Stewart



There was one more bump out there with a Kaweah name and I wanted it.

Kaweah Queen was an awkwardly placed bump that could only be accessed by going waaaaaaay out of our way but due to the fact it had a Kaweah name I wanted it. James and Amin declined but Jen was up for a long crappy slog.



So we woke up at first light and set off across the basin.



We ran in to patches of hard snow and way more loose rock than we really wanted to deal with.



In fact the majority of the climb was just loose crap.



First stop was Lawson Peak, another minor bump that did look rather prominent from inside the basin. We took a short break then headed along the ridge for Queen.



Periodically we dropped down off the ridge but the rock was so loose every step was a pain.



On Queen we found a small register with unreadable scraps of paper.



We had a different view of the Kaweahs from here. Black is the prominent peak on the right while Red is the one to the left of the major snow notch.



And now we had to go down.

Despite the nasty loose slopes we were making decent time and decided to head for a third peak. We had two logical options.



Lion looked awesome and allegedly had a few 4th class moved to climb from this side.



Stewart was a bit closer to camp and was the peak James and Amin had been thinking about climbing while we were off chasing Queen and Lawson.



We decided to do Stewart and try to get everyone to do Lion the following day.



Stewart is part of the ridgeline that includes Lion, Eagle Scout, and Lippincott. Instead of the loose mess of the Kaweahs the rock was refreshingly solid.



Jen and I had fun climbing up a prominent ramp from the basin.



Kaweahs are in the back to the left, we're camped at the clump of trees above and to the right of the lake.

Along the way we ran into James and Amin headed down. They told us what to expect up top and headed down for a bath in the lake and an early night.

Jen and I topped out and spent a good amount of time sitting on the somewhat awkward summit block.



We could look back at Queen and Lawson to the left of Black.

As remote as we were the big annoyance was the air traffic up above. The register made reference to the loud and excessive over flights by military jets. It literally seemed to be every 15-30 minutes.

We eventually decided to head down hoping to make the lake before dark for a quick bath.



Instead of going down the ramp we swung to the south and took some rather nice slab ramps back to the basin.

We made the lake while it was still in the sun and took a quick dip in the lake. We'd been wearing the same clothes for several days so they benefited from the wash as much as we did.

The moment I got out I was swarmed by mosquitos.



Jen was all for staying longer but I got us moving on account of being eaten alive.



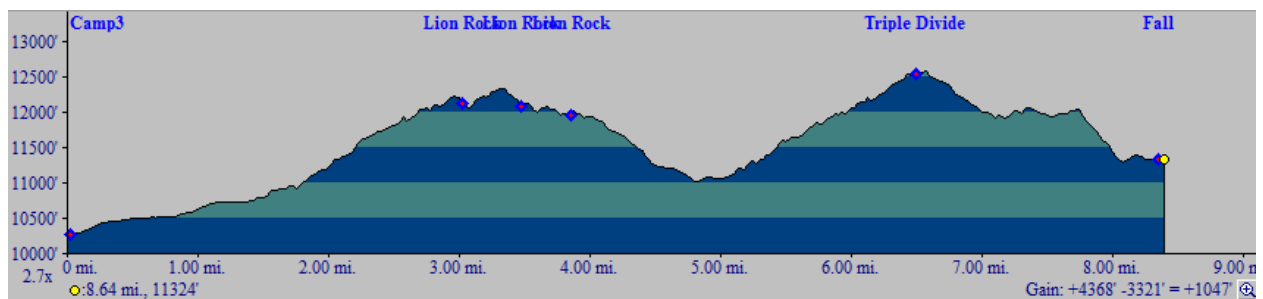
We got back to camp as the guys were eating dinner. They'd taken a bit more time to swim and had made it back well ahead of us.



Other than dinner the main entertainment was Jen trying to repair her boot which had split open. I gave her some cord and she did her best to stitch the leather back together but never did get it to hold up.

I slept well after another good long day.

Day Six: Lion, Triple Divide, and The Fall



So after James and Amin took it easy the day before our entire group was once again ready to head out for some real fun.



Lion was located at the northern end of 9 Lakes Basin and Secor claimed climbing via the southern ridge involved class 3 with two 4th class moves. After days of loose crappy talus this sounded perfect!



The approach across the basin went quickly and we scooted around lake 10,725 on the west side over some slick consolidated snow.



Then we headed up slope and gained the ridge.





The ridge was mostly 2nd class with some 3rd class bits thrown in here but good scrambling. We did come across two short bits of 4th class, one requiring a traverse across a face with decent holds then a small jump over a gap immediately after.



This was actually Amin's first time doing 4th class. Trial by fire.

Everyone took it slow and we made it across without incident.



Separate from the actual peak was a small pinnacle that had looked rather significant from below. We decided to call it Little Lion and climb it just for grins.



Lion itself is in the background.

After a short break we scrambled back down and continued to the summit where we found another well visited register.



And of course we struck a pose...



Jen and I were feeling rather energetic and starting eying Triple Divide Peak another canyon over while the other two were thinking of heading back to camp and taking it easy.



The descent was actually a bit tricky as we had some steep slabs leading down to consolidated snow with gaps in between big enough to swallow someone.



But with some care we were all down. Jen and I set off for our peak, Amin headed back towards camp, and James decided to grab a few of the nearby unnamed pinnacles.





Our route involved dropping 800 ft then climbing 600 or so to Copper Mine Pass. From there it was about half a mile and a thousand feet up what turned out to be a beautiful 3rd class ridge.



The climb up the western ridge of Triple Divide was one of the nicer scrambles of the trip. Good solid rock and an interesting route (basically staying right on the ridge worked about 95% of the time) made for a good time.



Up top we found another well visited register though most people seemed to climb the peak from the west or north instead of from Lion.

As much fun as we had coming up neither of us were looking forward to backtracking and crossing the canyon again. We started eyeing the ridge to the south which would turn the climb into a nice loop and after consulting Secor (who claimed the nasty looking pinnacles we could see 1/3 of the way down were passable) we set off.



The ridge was indeed passable but not near as pleasant as the western ridge. We had to drop down the eastern side fairly often and ended up on yet more loose terrain.

There were some interesting 3rd+ class sections we had to down climb along the way.



Soon we were looking down in to Nine Lakes Basin. We both figured the hard part was over and we'd be in camp in another hour or two.



The descent turned out to be a little more challenging than it appeared from above. We found footprints and figured James had come down this way but soon found ourselves on a large slab with every apparent descent route cliffing out.

After exhausting all options it appeared we were going to have to climb back up a few hundred feet and traverse further north along the ridge before we could descend.

As we started up I noticed a ramp leading down towards the rock field below. This looked promising but Jen didn't want to down climb it only to find we needed to come back up. I decided to try it.

Aaaand that's where things went wrong.



It went down quite a ways with one short questionable section before ultimately ending at a drop just big enough I didn't want to try jumping down and risk a broken ankle. I yelled up to Jen not to come down and started back up.

The section I'd found questionable on the way down was equally daunting coming back up. It was a small dihedral with a steep slab lacking much in the way of features to climb. I managed to get a foothold in the crack and started up the short section.

It didn't hold. I slid down and went out of control.

I skittered down the slab, went off in to the air, and after a roughly 25 ft fall hit the rocks below. I remember thinking distinctly that I was going to break my legs.

When I realized I was falling I had the automatic reaction to flip around which almost certainly saved me from a much worse injury. Instead of landing face down I took the majority of the impact on my hip and the pack I was wearing.

I never lost consciousness and have full memory of the slide and impact.

Immediately after I hit there was intense pain and I was having a very hard time breathing.

Jen was still up above and out of sight when I fell. She heard the rock fall and me cry out. I managed to yell up to Jen that I'd taken a fall and to be careful coming down before becoming distracted by the fact my vision was swimming and I felt like I was going to lose consciousness.

Later I found out it took her about 15 minutes to get down to me. I don't remember sitting there alone for that long but I may have been slightly distracted.

I was struggling just to breath and when Jen made it down to me and I warned her there was a good chance I was going to black out. With not a small amount of pain I'd managed to reposition so my head was between my legs which seemed to help though it made it even more difficult to breath.

It quickly became apparent I couldn't bear weight or bend my right knee past a certain point. In addition the sharp pain in my left chest which was keeping me from breathing became much worse when I attempted to move to the point where I could barely draw a fraction of a breath.

I wasn't going to be able to walk out of there.

As an added bonus Jen was going to have to run for help which meant I was going to be alone out there for at least a few hours until James and Amin could get to me.

I'd fallen on a scree slope and the nearest flat patch was down by the lake maybe 100 ft below. My initial attempts to move made it clear that was out of my range.

There was a small depression against the wall I'd fallen off of maybe 5 feet away. I had Jen pull one of the emergency blankets from my ten essentials bag (after an incident in Death Valley a few years back I carry two) and spread it on the ground after clearing as many of the sharp rocks as she could.

Getting over to it wasn't a fast or pleasant process. Every movement made the pain much worse and made it all but impossible to breath.

Once I made it over we did our best to prop me up in a neutral position using my pack and wrapped me in the rain jackets and insulating layers from both of our packs.

I went through with Jen what she'd need to do. First she had to get back to camp and have James and Amin hurry back with sleeping bags, pads, and whatever else they could bring. Then being the fastest hiker of the group she was going to need to hike over Kaweah Gap to the Bearpaw Ranger Station some 10 miles away and let them know what had happened.

I had Jen repeat a description of my injuries back a few times and then she took off.

The next few hours felt like an eternity. I was perched on some uncomfortable rocks and every movement to try and relieve the discomfort resulted in me sliding down off the pack and dislodging the jackets around my legs. I was getting colder and breathing was becoming an increasing struggle. As an added bonus the sun was also going down dropping the temperature significantly making our insulation job increasingly insufficient.

After an hour or two I was shivering uncontrollably which was causing me to tense up. When I tensed there was a sharp pain on the left side of my chest and I was unable to breathe at all. I then had to force myself to relax before I could breathe again. Fun times.

For a while I could see down below but as I shifted and slid off the pack bit by bit my view was eventually limited to the sky and the rock directly above me.

After what seemed like an eternity I heard James yell from below that they were coming.

James and Amin had been back in camp relaxing when Jen arrived around 7 pm and told them that I had taken a fall. They'd done an admirable job of gathering food and supplies and climbing back up to me with heavy loads.



As soon as he got to me James went in to action and after some significant effort and discomfort they managed to get both my and Amin's sleeping pads under me and Jen's sleeping bag around me. On top of this they added my own sleeping quilt which soon had me feeling significantly warmer.



Amin was actually carrying a SPOT device which is capable of sending out an emergency 911 signal that should result in help being sent. Unfortunately the battery had run out earlier in the trip. Fortunately we had a number of spare AA batteries. Unfortunately those were alkali batteries and in a design decision that in no way improves my already skeptical view of the unit's reliability it only takes lithium. Fortunately James had some lithium batteries in his GPS. Unfortunately these were a bit rundown and soon after he put them in Amin reported the unit was flashing the low battery indicator.

Jen had left running for the ranger but we didn't know if she'd made it. We had a beacon going off but we didn't know if the signal was getting out. Beyond that there was nothing to do but wait.

I didn't get much sleep that night.

Day Seven: A Long Night, My First Helicopter Ride, and I Swear I'm Not Homeless

The fall had happened around 5 pm Thursday. James and I had discussed the possibility of the nearby naval station responding and I had some hope we'd see a helicopter that night as the weather was incredibly clear.

That hope went away sometime around 11 pm and I did my best to just get through a rather uncomfortable night.



The next morning the sun came up and there was still no sign of help. I was starting to think about what we'd do if neither the SPOT nor Jen had managed to get out.

At 7:15 a helicopter swooped in and James and Amin flagged it down with their sleeping bags.



Unfortunately being tucked against a rock wall in the middle of a steep slope meant they couldn't exactly land right next to me and the snow fields below were icy from having frozen overnight. The helicopter put down at the lake below and yelled up they were looking at how to get to me.

(I have pictures of all of this partially because I kept insisting that the others take pictures. Priorities!)

After what seemed like a very long time the SAR team decided to short haul someone below the helicopter and drop them nearby.



This was Melanie (or Melody, none of us can remember her exact name)



She had her work cut out for her as I was rather tucked in against the rock.

Right about then Jen arrived. She'd made it to Bearpaw the previous night only to find that there was no ranger due to the position having been eliminated due to budget cuts. There was however someone with a radio and she spent the next two hours repeating the story to a sequence of people before they finally agreed to send a helicopter in the morning.

She left Bearpaw at 4:30 am that morning and hauled ass back to where I'd fallen having spent the entire night wondering if I was ok.

She said when she got back to the fall site and heard me attempting to joke with the ranger she was very relieved.

Melanie had a collapsible backboard which she did her best to manhandle me on to with the help of the others.



She also put me in c spine precaution despite the fact the fall had happened 15 hours ago and I'd been ambulatory afterwards.



With not a small amount of effort the four of them managed to get me moved down to a flat rock where the helicopter could pick us up. I wasn't exactly on the board correctly and at times I was basically being held on by the chin strap. Eventually she became more concerned with my airway than c spine.



Everyone else had to back off and the copter fired up and dropped a weighted line.



I was hooked in along with Melanie and we had a short ride down to the lake.



This would have been incredibly fun but I really couldn't see much being being closed up in the body bag. My view was of the sky and the bottom of the helicopter.





A video of this can be seen at: www.youtube.com/watch?v=tQ7E-fvCQvA&feature=youtu.be

They dropped us down by the lake (surprisingly gently all things considered) and loaded me inside the helicopter. (I assumed I'd be riding in the cage outside)

Sadly I couldn't remember the M.A.S.H. theme to sing as all this was going on.

This was actually my first helicopter ride. Of course as I was strapped down and in c spine precaution I couldn't really see anything other than Melanie's visor and the radio plugin on the ceiling but why dwell on the negative.



The helicopter took off leaving Jen, James, and Amin behind to break camp and transport all the gear back to the trailhead. This meant they'd all be carrying very heavy loads as almost all of my gear was in my pack or back at camp. It would take them about a day and a half to get back out to the Mineral King trailhead and drive down the mountain.

The helicopter landed in Ash Mountain where I was transferred into an ambulance which took me on a 40 minute ride down the road to Visalia and the Kaweah Delta hospital.

The EMT in the back was a really nice guy. His first name started with a J but I can't recall his full name which is too bad. I told him about my website so hopefully if he ever reads this he'll drop me a line.

One of the first things he asked me was how attached I was to my clothing. Considering my only replacements were sitting in a vehicle that I wouldn't be seeing for a day or two at best (not to mention I go through gear fast enough without anyone purposefully cutting them off) my answer was that I was pretty damn attached.

He helped me out of the jacket and said he'd argue on my behalf for them not to cut my pants off. Again, nice guy.

He put an IV in and took some vitals but we had a good long time to chat before we arrived. Unfortunately he couldn't do much about the backboard which was fast becoming my rather singular and painful focus.

Among other things I found out he was actually leaving for a month backpacking in Ireland soon.

We talked about the fall and he commented I seemed to have gotten off rather light considering the distance I'd fallen and I started to think towards getting out of the ER and in to a hotel if at all possible. I was also starting to think on the fact I hadn't had much to eat recently and the conversation turned to what the best Mexican food in Visalia was. (Priorities!)

The EMT was nice enough to ask around and track me down later in the hospital to give me a piece of paper with the name and address of the restaurant on it.

Of course about this time it dawned on me that I was going to have a small issue. My phone, wallet, ID, credit cards, and cash were all in my vehicle at the Mineral King trailhead. Its remote enough taking a taxi back up the mountain would be prohibitively expensive even if I had the car key I'd left with Jen and company.

Doh.

EMT guy was nice enough he actually stuck 20 bucks in my pocket and told me to go get some Mexican food once they let me out.

They rolled me into the ER and had me in a room rather quickly. I was begging to get off the backboard in between apologizing for my rather fragrant state.

A doctor came in along with a gaggle of people with the word **Student** written in big bold letters on their nametags. Unfortunately his focus seemed to be much more on explaining the whys of his decisions to them instead of giving me any information and several of the things he directed them to do like clean out my (numerous) bloody scrapes never happened.

They did however finally rule out c spine injury and take me off that infernal backboard. When my abused rear end hit the thin substandard hospital bed I'm pretty sure I was so happy I proposed marriage to the entire room on the spot.

At first he didn't want to take any x-rays but I helpfully pointed out I couldn't breathe or bear weight on my right knee. He reconsidered and ordered x-rays of my knee and chest.

After that they prodded me a bit the doctor gave me a supposedly mild pain shot. Except I hadn't really had anything to eat or drink all day except for a granola bar and a small gulp of water and I was a bit lacking in sleep so it really knocked me on my butt.

I vaguely remember getting x-rays of my knee and chest and getting several visits from some nice ladies in the financial counseling department who didn't seem to quite believe me when I said that despite appearances I was a software engineer and actually had health insurance.

That's how I ended up getting assigned to Mike the social worker.

I liked Mike. He actually said it wasn't uncommon for this to happen when people were hurt in the park and started to go over options with me. I had been starting to get images of ending up at a homeless shelter when someone mentioned there was a Marriott across the street.

Marriot loves me. It had something to do with 75+ nights spent in the hotel this year and somewhere north of 50+ annually over the last 4 years or so. I had plenty of reward points that could pay for a room I just couldn't prove who I was.

Mike took my information and went off to argue my case.

The nurses seemed to find it amusing when I kept commenting they were going to dump me out by the dumpster but I'd made sure to get the EMT's promise they'd pick me up and take me for Mexican food if that happened.

I managed to doze a bit here and there amid the various slurred discussions with the financial services ladies.

Then I woke up to the doctor sitting by the bed. He said that according to the x-rays all the major bones seemed to be where they were supposed to be though he couldn't rule out hairline fractures. His rather succinct diagnoses is I'd come off very lucky and was just "really beat up" He also said I looked like I needed a bit of rest after what I'd been through so they were leaving me in the room for a while before I'd be discharged.

I didn't want to be disagreeable but I was forced to point out I couldn't really sit up or walk. His response was to send in a nurse with crutches and a knee immobilizer.

Right about the time the nurse was explaining how to use the crutches Mike came back and said Marriott had been very accommodating and had a room waiting for me across the street. Wohoo! No dumpster or YMCA for me!

Of course I had to get over to the hotel which is how I met Richard the mental health officer. In addition to getting a ride in a helicopter and an ambulance now I was going to be chauffeured in one of those cars with the caged back seat.

Mike made a comment at this point that they tell all the mental ill patients they are taking them to the Marriott when they are carting them off to the nut house. Again, I liked Mike.

Getting me off the bed in to a wheel chair and into the vehicle was a painful production but I soon found myself being wheeled into a rather fancy Marriott hotel. They ladies at the front desk were very accommodating giving me freebies from the market and doing their best to see I was looked after.

I was wheeled into a room on the 8th floor where Richard left me.

I could barely move around the room on my own and the only clothes I had were what I'd been wearing for the last 6-ish days. I was slightly less than fresh.

The hotel was actually nice enough to send someone out to Walmart and grab me a shirt, shorts, and underwear. This let me get showered which was a relief and I did my best to scrub out my various wounds.

The biggest downside (outside the fact I couldn't go for Mexican food and had to settle for pizza) was without ID I wasn't able to get pain pills. The front desk brought me Advil from the market which unfortunately didn't do a thing.

It was another long night though I have to admit the pillows were a bit of an improvement over the rocks of the previous night.

Day Eight: God I Hate Television

Without any real painkillers it hurt to even lie on the bed in most positions. I had no books, no phone, no internet access, and no way to contact anyone beyond a cell number for James where I left word of where I was.

The only way I had to pass the time was the TV so I ended up watching waaaaay to many episodes of some banal show about people who write parking tickets and impound cars.

I finally ordered an overpriced pay per view movie to get a bit of relief. When your checked in without a credit card this sets off all manner of alarms with the Marriott system.

A little after 1 pm Saturday afternoon there was a knock at the door and Amin and James were standing there. (Jen was driving around the block trying to find a place to park my car.)

After we swapped stories we went and turned in my prescription for pain pills and while we waited went to the Mexican food restaurant that had been recommended.

Marriott was very kind through the entire episode. The room was paid for with points but they were nice enough to comp everything but one meal and the movie.

Jen drove me home while I sat in the passenger seat wishing the pain pills were much stronger.

Annnnddd...

So in the end I made it back home after 8 days, 9 peaks, a messed up knee, some very painful ribs, and another large bottle of pain pills.

My boss at Crown gave my full support and let me work from home for the week instead of flying right back out to Boise.

Unfortunately this little event put a rather big dent in my end of summer climbing schedule. I was reluctantly forced to cancel my trips to climb Temple Crag and Gayley and another outing to Mineral King to get Florence and Vandever.

Injury-wise the ribs were a constant remainder for the next few weeks of why it's a bad idea to run afoul of gravity but eventually they died down to the occasional twinge and went away completely. The knee

was another issue as it soon became apparent when the swelling went down that I had some non-miniscule free floating bodies inside.

I did manage to get out a few weeks later though I had to take it really easy...



And with some help from friends even managed to make it up Starr King about a month after the fall.



Having canceled my climbs I did my best to limp around and do what I could.





I never did hear from the SAR folks and my insurance knocked the ER charge down to a reasonable level. Interestingly enough it was the ambulance charge that was the worst coming in at \$2k before I eventually convinced my insurance to pay half.

Note to self, next time I take a fall like that have the SAR folks drop my backboard off at the side of the road with my arm untied so I can hitchhike...